GETTING STARTED WITH POLICY GOVERNANCE

This chapter shows ACME's mature governance in action, but few organizations start at that level, so don't feel overwhelmed. Governance develops gradually as systems and teams mature. The key is to begin small, using tools and practices that establish visibility and accountability early on. Here are a few things you can do to get started.

Begin with decision documentation. If your organization hasn't yet implemented an IGA system or a policy engine, start with Architectural Decision Records (ADRs). Recording the reasons behind important access or authorization choices builds a foundation for future governance. An ADR doesn't have to be complicated; it is simply a *version-controlled* document that provides a structured record of the context, decision, and consequences. Over time, ADRs serve as the link between intent and implementation.

Introduce ownership and conduct reviews. Assign ownership to each access-related configuration or policy. Ownership is the first step toward governance. Schedule regular reviews—quarterly is sufficient initially—to ensure policies still meet current business needs.

Add version control and peer review. Move policies and access rules into a version-controlled repository and require at least one peer review before merging changes. Use version control to manage ownership and policy reviews. This simple adjustment provides traceability, accountability, and collective oversight without adding heavy processes.

Layer in IGA or perform identity hygiene. When your identity environment becomes complex enough that manual management leads to errors, adopt Identity Governance and Administration (IGA) tools or at least implement automated workflows for joiners, movers, and leavers. IGA offers the dependable data foundation that policy governance relies on.

Build on evidence, not ceremony. Governance succeeds when it produces evidence, not paperwork. Focus primarily on artifacts that can be inspected like ADRs, version history, logs, and ownership records. These